

TAMIL NADU & KARNATAKA ORIGIN

Upma

Spiced Semolina Porridge with Vegetables
South India's Most Comforting Morning Bowl

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Upma

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Upma

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Humble Dish That Defines South Indian Home Cooking

No dish is more closely associated with the South Indian home kitchen than upma. It appears on weekday morning tables across Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, and Kerala, cooked in fifteen minutes from pantry staples, reliably satisfying, infinitely adaptable. Outside South India, upma sometimes carries an unfair reputation as a plain or unexciting dish — a characterisation that reveals nothing about the cooking and everything about the cook.

A properly made upma is neither stodgy nor bland. The roasting of the semolina before it meets the liquid is what separates restaurant-quality upma from a disappointing porridge: dry-roasted rava develops a nutty depth, and when it meets hot, well-tempered water in a single addition, it cooks into individual grains rather than a gummy mass. The tempering — mustard seeds, curry leaves, green chillies, onions, ginger — provides the aromatic base that lifts the mild semolina.

Upma appears in Sanskrit culinary texts as 'upappu' — a dish of roasted grain cooked with seasonings — and has been made in some form across the subcontinent for centuries. The South Indian version crystallised into its modern form with the adoption of semolina (introduced through Portuguese trade routes) in the 17th–18th centuries, replacing the original cracked grains.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Humble Dish That Defines South Indian Home Cooking, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

A staple of South Indian office and school canteens — the dish most associated with weekday morning routine across Tamil Nadu and Karnataka. Considered an essential part of every South Indian cook's repertoire; the ability to make a good upma is a benchmark of basic kitchen competence. Traditionally served with coconut chutney in Tamil Nadu; in Karnataka it is served with sugar and pickle — a sweet-savoury pairing unique to the region. Upma is offered as prasadam at some South Indian temples, making it one of the few savory tiffin dishes with religious significance.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

5m	8m	10m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	ROASTING TIME	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Heavy kadai or deep saucepan (a wide base helps with even roasting and prevents lumps)
- Wooden spoon or silicone spatula for constant stirring
- Separate small pan or kettle for heating water
- Lid for the pan (needed for the final steam step)

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Upma is best eaten within 30 minutes of cooking — it thickens significantly as it cools and the texture becomes stodgy. If making ahead, undercook very slightly and reheat with 2–3 tablespoons of hot water, stirring over medium heat until it loosens. Refrigerates for up to 1 day; do not freeze. Roasted semolina (without cooking) can be stored in an airtight container for up to 2 weeks, making breakfast preparation significantly faster.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the upma

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Fine semolina (rava / sooji)	1 cup	160 g	1 katori
Water	2 cups	480 ml	2 katori
Oil or ghee	2 tbsp	28 ml	2 tbsp
Mustard seeds	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Urad dal (split)	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Chana dal (split chickpeas)	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Fresh curry leaves	12–15	12–15	12–15
Green chillies, slit	3	3	3
Onion, finely chopped	1 medium	100 g	1 medium
Fresh ginger, grated	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Salt	¾ tsp	4 g	to taste
Fresh coriander, chopped	2 tbsp	8 g	2 tbsp
Lemon juice	1 tbsp	15 ml	1 tbsp

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Fine semolina (sooji/rava) is the base and cannot be replaced for authentic upma. Coarse semolina produces a more rustic, grainier texture — acceptable but different. Both urad dal and chana dal in the tempering are important for texture (they fry crisp and provide tiny crunchy bites) — skip one if unavailable but not both. Ghee produces a richer, more aromatic upma than neutral oil; a combination of 1 tbsp ghee + 1 tbsp oil is the best of both worlds. Lemon juice at the end is optional but recommended — it brightens the flavour significantly.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Dry Roasting the Semolina

01 DRY ROAST THE SEMOLINA

Place a wide, heavy kadai or deep pan over medium heat. Add the semolina and dry roast, stirring continuously, for 6–8 minutes until it turns fragrant and very slightly golden — not browned, just lightly toasted. The colour change will be subtle; the aroma is the main indicator. Remove from heat immediately and set aside.

Chef tip. Roasting the rava is the single most important step in upma. Unroasted rava cooks into a sticky, gummy mass; well-roasted rava cooks into individual, fluffy grains. Do not skip this step or rush it — 6–8 minutes of constant stirring at medium heat.

02 HEAT THE WATER

In a separate small pan or kettle, bring 2 cups of water to a full rolling boil. Keep it at a simmer. Hot water is essential — adding cold water to the tempering creates lumps and uneven cooking.

03 PREPARE THE TEMPERING INGREDIENTS

While the water heats, gather and prepare all tempering ingredients: onion finely chopped, ginger grated, curry leaves washed and dried, green chillies slit. Have everything ready before heating the oil — the tempering moves fast.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Dry Roasting the Semolina, continued



COOKING CHECKPOINT

Properly roasted semolina is key. It should smell nutty and toasty (like popcorn or roasted grain), feel dry and separate when pressed between fingers, and look very slightly golden — not white (under-roasted) and not brown (over-roasted). Taste a few grains; they should be slightly crunchy and flavourful, not raw-tasting.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Tempering, Combining & Finishing

04 BUILD THE TEMPERING

Heat the oil or ghee in the same kadai over medium-high heat. Add the mustard seeds and wait for them to pop and splutter — this takes 30–60 seconds. Add the urad dal and chana dal; fry for 30 seconds until golden. Add the curry leaves (they will splutter dramatically — stand back), green chillies, then onion and ginger. Fry for 3–4 minutes until the onion turns translucent and slightly golden.

Chef tip. The order of tempering matters: mustard first (needs high heat to pop), then dals (fry crisp), then curry leaves (aromatics), then onion (longer cooking time). Adding onion too early or too late produces a different flavour.

05 ADD THE HOT WATER

Pour the boiling water into the kadai carefully (it will sputter). Add salt and stir. Bring to a rolling boil over high heat.

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Tempering, Combining & Finishing, continued



06 ADD THE ROASTED SEMOLINA

Reduce the heat to medium. Add the dry roasted semolina to the boiling water in a STEADY STREAM, stirring vigorously and continuously with the other hand as you pour. This is the critical moment — the semolina must be incorporated without lumps. Stir for 60–90 seconds without stopping.

Chef tip. The simultaneous pour-and-stir technique is what separates a smooth upma from a lumpy one. Have someone pour the semolina while you stir, or work the ladle and bowl simultaneously. Never dump the semolina in all at once.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Tempering, Combining & Finishing, continued

07 STEAM-FINISH AND ADD LEMON

Once all the semolina is incorporated and the mixture pulls away from the sides of the pan, reduce the heat to the lowest setting. Cover with a lid and cook for 2–3 minutes. Open, fluff with a fork, add the fresh coriander and lemon juice, mix well, and serve.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Covering the pan too early (before the semolina is fully incorporated and the mixture is cohesive) traps steam unevenly and creates pockets of raw, undercooked semolina. Incorporate fully, see the mixture come together cleanly, THEN cover to steam-finish.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Tamil Nadu Style

- Served with coconut chutney — the classic pairing that provides sweetness and fat to balance the spiced semolina.
- A teaspoon of ghee poured over hot upma just before serving is the traditional home-cooking touch.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Karnataka Style

- Served with a pinch of sugar on the side and lime pickle — the sweet-savoury combination is a Karnataka regional distinction that surprises newcomers but is deeply traditional.
- Also served with a small bowl of curd (plain yogurt) to cool the spice of the green chillies.

Modern Style

- Mixed vegetable upma with green peas, carrot, and French beans added with the onion — a common school and office canteen preparation.
- A fried egg placed on top of upma is a popular home breakfast shortcut that adds protein.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

The Roasting Is Non-Negotiable

- Pre-roast a batch of 500g semolina and store it in an airtight jar for up to 2 weeks — this reduces morning upma preparation to under 10 minutes from start to serve.
- Do not rush the roast. A light golden colour and a nutty aroma indicate readiness; white semolina will produce gummy upma regardless of technique.

Water Ratio

- The standard ratio is 1 part semolina : 2 parts water, producing a firm, fluffy upma. For softer, creamier upma, use 2.25 parts water. Never use cold water — it produces irreversible lumps.
- Upma continues to absorb water as it sits; serve within 5 minutes of cooking or it will tighten.

THE LEMON FINISH

Lemon juice added at the very end (never during cooking) brightens all flavours and adds a freshness that transforms a good upma into an excellent one.

A tablespoon of cashews fried in the tempering oil before the mustard seeds adds crunch and richness — a restaurant-grade detail that takes 30 extra seconds.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

200 kcal	5 g	30 g	7 g	2 g
CALORIES (PER SERVING)	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with preparation method and serving size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Gluten, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Vegetable Upma	Green peas, diced carrot, and French beans added with the onion — the most common variation, found in school and office canteens across South India.
Rava Khichdi	A Karnataka variation made with semolina and lightly cooked mixed vegetables in a thicker, slightly wetter consistency — resembling a savory porridge.
Semiya Upma	Made with fine vermicelli (semiya) instead of semolina — a lighter, thinner-textured version popular in Tamil Nadu, cooked by the same tempering-and-water method.
Oats Upma	The modern health-conscious substitute replacing rava with rolled oats, prepared with the same South Indian tempering — more nutritious but different in texture.

My upma is lumpy – how do I prevent it?

Lumpy upma is almost always caused by adding cold water, adding the semolina to lukewarm water, or not stirring continuously during incorporation. Ensure the water is at a full boil before adding the semolina, and stir constantly as you pour it in a steady stream, never all at once.

My upma is sticky and gummy, not fluffy – what went wrong?

The semolina was not properly dry roasted. Raw or under-roasted semolina cooks into a sticky mass regardless of technique. Roast properly until fragrant and very slightly golden.

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Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I make upma without oil?

The tempering requires a fat medium for the mustard seeds and dals to cook properly. A very small amount (1 tsp) of oil works, but the flavour and texture are noticeably less rich. Ghee is highly recommended as even a small amount adds significant flavour.

How do I reheat upma without it turning into a solid block?

Add 3–4 tablespoons of hot water and a few drops of oil to the cold upma in a pan. Heat over medium flame while stirring — the water loosens the semolina and restores the original fluffy texture within 2–3 minutes.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Rava	semolina; fine-ground durum wheat, sold as 'sooji' or 'rava'; the base of upma, rava dosa, and rava idli.
Tempering (tadka)	spices and aromatics bloomed in hot oil; the first step that defines the flavour of the entire upma.
Urad dal / chana dal in tempering	added whole to the hot oil; they fry crisp and provide textural contrast in each bite of upma.
Semiya upma	the vermicelli variation; thinner and lighter than rava upma, popular in Tamil Nadu as a quick weekday breakfast.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Upma

5m ACTIVE PREP	8m ROASTING TIME
10m COOK TIME	4 SERVINGS
Easy DIFFICULTY	

UPMA

Fine semolina	160 g
Water	480 ml
Oil or ghee	28 ml
Mustard seeds	3 g
Urad dal	3 g
Chana dal	3 g
Fresh curry leaves	12–15
Green chillies	3
Onion	100 g
Fresh ginger	4 g
Salt	4 g
Fresh coriander	8 g
Lemon juice	15 ml

METHOD

01 **Dry roast the semolina.** Place a wide, heavy kadai or deep pan over medium heat.

02 **Heat the water.** In a separate small pan or kettle, bring 2 cups of water to a full rolling boil.

03 **Prepare the tempering ingredients.** While the water heats, gather and prepare all tempering ingredients: onion finely chopped, ginger grated, curry leaves washed and dried, green chillies slit.

04 **Build the tempering.** Heat the oil or ghee in the same kadai over medium-high heat.

05 **Add the hot water.** Pour the boiling water into the kadai carefully (it will sputter).

06 **Add the roasted semolina.** Reduce the heat to medium.

07 **Steam-finish and add lemon.** Once all the semolina is incorporated and the mixture pulls away from the sides of the pan, reduce the heat to the lowest setting.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Fine semolina	160 g	☐ Oil or ghee	28 ml
☐ Mustard seeds	3 g	☐ Urad dal	3 g
☐ Chana dal	3 g	☐ Fresh curry leaves	12–15
☐ Green chillies	3	☐ Onion	100 g
☐ Fresh ginger	4 g	☐ Salt	4 g
☐ Fresh coriander	8 g	☐ Lemon juice	15 ml

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